



Adaptive Coordination

A Protocol for Integrative Decision-Making

Practical guidance for groups navigating complex decisions across competing values, worldviews, and institutional logics.

By **Björn Kenneth Holmström**

with Claude, ChatGPT, DeepSeek, Gemini and Grok

Global Governance Frameworks

Adaptive Coordination: A Protocol for Integrative Decision-Making

A practical guide for groups navigating complex decisions across competing values, worldviews, and institutional logics.

This protocol is not a prescription but an invitation — a set of patterns to be adapted, abandoned, or reinvented as the situation demands. If it becomes a new orthodoxy, it has failed.

The fundamental shift

Most groups coordinate through a single inherited mode: follow the rules, optimize for the best argument, or seek consensus until everyone feels heard. Each mode works in some contexts and fails in others — but groups rarely notice they are *in* a mode, let alone that they could choose a different one.

Adaptive coordination changes this along several axes simultaneously:

- **Positions** → **Processes** — the focus shifts from defending views to designing how views interact
- **Opinions** → **Models** — participants offer testable framings of reality, not just preferences
- **Control** → **Coherence** — the aim is not to direct the outcome but to let the most functional outcome become visible
- **Debate** → **Exploration of reality** — disagreement becomes information, not threat

The core meta-move is this: **the group decides how to decide, and that itself becomes a conscious, flexible act rather than an inherited habit.**

Beyond systemic integration, there is a further capacity: collective sensing — not just "what's the smartest systemic choice?" but "what's trying to emerge here that none of us individually see yet?"

If there is a single invariant principle beneath all of this, it is: **the purpose of the protocol is to increase the system's ability to perceive reality accurately and respond coherently.** Everything else — phases, roles, practices — is optional, adaptable, and context-sensitive. This principle is the anchor that prevents the protocol from becoming a new form of rigidity.

When to use this protocol — and when not to

Not every decision warrants this level of process. Over-processing simple decisions will undermine credibility faster than anything else.

A quick filter: **Is the decision reversible?** If yes, bias toward action — try it, observe, adjust. Use authority or a quick advice process. Reserve the full protocol for decisions that are complex, high-stakes, or irreversible, where multiple value systems are genuinely in tension and the cost of getting it wrong is significant.

Similarly, this protocol assumes at least some psychological safety and shared purpose. In contexts dominated by acute survival pressure, begin with simpler structures that build trust, and gradually introduce elements as the ground stabilizes.

Why fixed-mode coordination gets stuck

Groups that default to a single coordination mode have characteristic failure patterns:

- **Procedural dominance** — defaulting to rules even when the situation demands adaptivity, treating deviation as disorder
- **Optimization dominance** — collapsing complex decisions into measurable trade-offs, ignoring second- and third-order effects
- **Consensus dominance** — conflating *being heard* with *having influenced the outcome*, producing meeting paralysis when full agreement proves impossible
- **Power dominance** — treating every meeting as a contest of wills, which can be energizing but suppresses quieter signals

More fundamentally, each mode *systematically avoids certain questions*. Consensus-oriented groups won't ask "is inclusion actually the priority here?" Optimization-oriented groups won't ask "are we optimizing the wrong thing?" Procedural groups won't ask "is the procedure itself the problem?"

Adaptive coordination is defined by its willingness to surface exactly these questions.

What adaptive coordination feels like

An adaptively coordinated meeting often feels:

- Slower at first, faster over time
- Less performative, more reflective
- Less adversarial, more co-creative
- More comfortable with uncertainty and unresolved tension

Two key experiential signatures:

Asking difficult questions — not to challenge *people*, but to challenge assumptions, system boundaries, hidden incentives, and second-order effects. Examples:

- "What problem are we *actually* trying to solve?"
- "What happens if we succeed?"
- "Who is not in the room that this decision affects?"
- "Which part of our identity are we protecting by not looking at this?"

Allowing time for thinking — silence becomes a feature, not a bug. Complex, systemic integration rarely happens spontaneously in a noisy room. Reflection pauses, writing before speaking, and iterative rounds replace reactive debate.

The protocol

This is not a rigid script — that would contradict its adaptive nature. It is a *pattern language* for meetings that can be entered at any phase and adapted to context.

Phase 0: Systemic preparation (before the meeting)

The most important work often happens before anyone gathers. This is where the facilitator metabolizes complexity so the group doesn't have to do it live:

- **Stakeholder mapping** — who is affected? Who holds relevant perspectives? Who is likely to feel threatened?

- **Coordination mode scanning** — what orientations are likely to be present? Procedural, strategic, relational, power-based? Where are potential collisions?
- **Decision mode pre-framing** — what mode *might* fit? (Held lightly, to be confirmed or adjusted by the group)
- **Complexity read** — is this simple, complicated, or complex? Does it involve a solvable problem or an ongoing polarity?

A well-prepared facilitator makes the meeting feel almost effortless — because the complexity was metabolized beforehand. This preparation is private and provisional, not imposed.

Phase 1: Ground the field

Brief orientation. Not a therapy circle, but not a pure agenda-setting exercise either. The question is:

Where is your attention right now? What are you bringing into this room?

This serves multiple functions: it gives the facilitator a read on the group's state, it creates a moment of arrival, and it models the principle that the *quality of attention* matters as much as the content discussed.

For the system: the facilitator may also name the shared purpose — what is this group in service of, beyond the immediate agenda? This can be as simple as a sentence.

Phase 2: Contextualize — question the question

Before solving a problem, spend real time ensuring the group is addressing the *right* problem.

- Is this a symptom or a root cause?
- What level of complexity are we dealing with — simple (just decide), complicated (analyze trade-offs), or complex (probe and sense)?
- What system dynamics are generating this issue?
- Is this a *problem to be solved* or a *polarity to be managed*? Tensions like speed vs. quality, centralization vs. decentralization, or candor vs. care cannot be resolved — only navigated. If the group is endlessly debating two valid poles, name the polarity

and shift the question from "which is right?" to "how do we get the benefits of both while minimizing the downsides of both?"

This is where the difficult questions live. Frame it as a duty: "Our job right now is to find the questions we're avoiding."

Output: A shared map of the complexity landscape — tentative, explicit about uncertainty.

Phase 3: Gather differentiated input

Collect perspectives without requiring them to agree with one another. Use rounds (a Sociocratic method): everyone speaks without interruption.

Critically, *explicitly invite different modes of intelligence:*

- **Procedural:** "Does this align with our core principles and mandates? What is the proper process?"
- **Strategic:** "What does the data say? What are the trade-offs and measurable outcomes?"
- **Relational:** "How will this impact people's sense of belonging and trust? Who might feel excluded or harmed?"
- **Power-aware:** "What are the real dynamics at play? What needs force or decisiveness to move?"

Allow silence between contributions. Allow people to speak from their natural orientation without correction. The facilitator's job is to hold the systemic frame, not to push anyone toward it.

A note on power: Rounds help, but structural power does not vanish because everyone gets a turn. When a director and a junior staff member are in the same room, the junior's round will be shaped by that asymmetry. Concrete mitigations: anonymous written input before verbal rounds, pre-meeting contributions weighted equally regardless of role, or reverse hierarchy speaking order (junior voices first). Name the dynamic rather than pretending it isn't there.

Phase 4: Asynchronous processing (when warranted)

For complex decisions, *break the meeting apart temporally*. Allow a set period — hours to days — for individuals to digest the mapping, let connections form below conscious awareness, and formulate integrative responses.

Use collaborative asynchronous tools (documents, shared boards) where people can add thoughts as they arise. This is countercultural in most organizations, which is exactly why it matters. Introverts, deep processors, and systems thinkers all need this.

Not every decision warrants this phase. The facilitator reads the complexity and decides.

Phase 5: Integration sensing

Reconvene. The question is not yet "what should we do?" but:

What patterns do you notice across what's been said? What's emerging?

This is the collective sensing move — listening for the signal beneath the positions. The facilitator acts as a weaver: "Our strategic analysis suggests speed. Our relational concern is about leaving people behind. Our principles require proper mandate. How might we design a solution that serves all three?"

The "empty chair" — explicitly represent the voice of stakeholders not present: the wider ecosystem, future generations, the community downstream. Ask: "What would this decision look like from their perspective?"

Other sensing practices (use what fits the group's readiness):

- **Pattern recognition round:** "What's the one word or image that captures where you sense we are?" Notice what clusters.
- **The two-question check:** "What feels clear?" and "What feels unclear?" — the gap between them is often where the real decision lives.
- **Embodied check:** "How does this potential direction land in your body — not your analysis, your felt sense?" This requires sufficient safety but can surface information that cognition misses.

- **Pre-mortem:** "Imagine we made this decision and it failed. How did it fail?" This inverts the usual optimism bias and reveals risks the group is collectively avoiding.

Phase 6: Decision mode selection

This is where adaptive coordination most visibly differs from fixed-mode approaches. Instead of defaulting to a single decision method, the group *consciously selects* the mode that fits the decision:

- **Authority** — one person decides (appropriate when speed matters or expertise is concentrated)
- **Advice process** — one person decides after consulting affected parties and experts (not required to compromise). The decision-maker must be identified *before* advice is gathered — ambiguity here causes regression to power struggles or consensus-seeking.
- **Consent** — the proposal moves forward unless someone identifies a substantial objection (a systemic risk, not a preference). This replaces consensus without losing its inclusion value.
- **Consensus** — full agreement, used sparingly for truly foundational decisions
- **Distributed experimentation** — multiple approaches are tried in parallel, with a review point

Name the mode explicitly, and name *why* it fits. This makes the process legible to everyone: procedurally-oriented participants see clear rules, strategically-oriented participants see the logic, relationally-oriented participants know their voice counted, action-oriented participants know a decision will happen.

Under pressure: When decision latency creates systemic risk, collapse to authority or advice process immediately. The key distinction is between *true urgency* (the building is on fire) and *perceived urgency* (someone's discomfort with uncertainty). Groups can pre-define fallback modes for crisis conditions, so the shift doesn't feel like a regression — it was anticipated.

Phase 7: Translate for different audiences

A decision made in systems language may be illegible or alienating to stakeholders operating from different orientations. The group explicitly discusses translation:

- "How do we communicate this to the parts of the organization that need to see clear procedure and authority?"
- "How do we frame it so the strategic value is visible?"
- "How do we convey the care and inclusion that went into the process?"

This is not manipulation — it is the recognition that the same decision can be truthfully described in multiple value languages, and that effective implementation requires meeting people where they are.

Phase 8: Close with what remains

Don't pretend everything is wrapped up. Explicitly name:

- What was decided and in what mode
- What remains unresolved and when it will be revisited
- What feedback signals will tell the group if the decision is wrong — define 1–3 leading indicators (weak signals), not just lagging KPIs
- What thresholds or conditions would trigger reconsideration
- What worked well in the process itself

Every decision is a hypothesis in a living system. Frame it that way. Schedule a lightweight check-in (even 15 minutes) to ask: "What is the system telling us now that we couldn't see before?" This distinguishes adaptive coordination's "decide and learn" from fixed-mode "decide and defend."

Including diverse orientations without collapsing

The trap for adaptive coordination is designing a process so meta-aware that it becomes inaccessible, or so enamored with integration that it fails to actually decide.

The key principle: **each coordination orientation needs to see its own values reflected in the structure, even though the structure itself transcends any single orientation.** These accommodations are not compromises — they are genuinely good features of a meeting that also happen to create entry points for each mindset.

Orientation	Core need in meetings	How the protocol serves it
Survival	Safety, immediate threat reduction	Acknowledgment of survival concerns without framing them as dysfunction; bio-breaks, movement, reasonable duration; not expecting sophisticated functioning when basic safety is absent
Belonging	Shared meaning, group identity	The grounding ritual of Phase 1; the closing
Action/power	Decisiveness, momentum	Explicit decision authority in Phase 6; space for direct truth-telling
Procedural	Rules, sequence, clarity	Clear phase structure; named decision modes; documented outcomes
Strategic	Efficiency, outcomes, logic	Contextualizing prevents wasted effort; strategic framing throughout
Relational	Voice, care, inclusion	Rounds without interruption; silence for processing; relational questions

A facilitator practicing adaptive coordination uses *dynamic translation* — the same meeting, experienced through different layers. One person hears clear structure. Another hears strategic optimization. Another hears inclusive dialogue. The underlying system serves all of them.

Over time, participants may naturally develop comfort with multiple modes — not because they are pushed, but because functional results build trust in the process.

Common failure modes

Even well-intended attempts at adaptive coordination fail when:

- "Open discussion" collapses into endless processing (no decision ever emerges)
- "Efficiency" collapses into dominance by the loudest or most analytically fluent voice
- "Structure" regresses into rigidity (the protocol itself becomes sacred and unchallengeable)
- Systems thinking becomes overly abstract (elegant models that no one can act on)

- Collective sensing becomes vague and ungrounded (sensing without deciding)
- The group treats participants with different orientations as "less developed" — which reproduces the very fixed-mode thinking it claims to transcend

The facilitator as single point of failure. This protocol places enormous weight on the facilitator — reading complexity, selecting modes, translating dynamically. This creates specific risks:

- **Over-steering** — covert control disguised as "holding the frame"
- **The map trap** — treating a model of the group as if it were the group; diagnosing participants, labeling orientations, subtly privileging those who "get it"
- **The integration trap** — forcing synthesis before its time, because the facilitator needs the elegance more than the system does
- **Abstraction bypass** — using systems language or collective sensing to avoid the hard, concrete work of deciding

The safeguard: the facilitator must be willing to be *seen through* by the group. If someone says "this feels like manipulation," the response is genuine curiosity, not a diagnosis of their limitations. The long-term goal is distributed facilitation — where anyone in the group can invoke a phase change, name a polarity, or call for an empty chair perspective. The facilitator works to make themselves unnecessary.

The antidote to all failure modes is the same: return to the question "*what actually serves the health of the whole system right now?*" — and be willing to hear an answer that challenges the group's self-image.

A note on scale

This protocol as written fits groups of roughly 5–15 people. Beyond that, it needs structural adaptation:

- **Medium groups (15–40):** Break into subgroups with a shared frame, each with a facilitator. Phases 2 and 3 happen in parallel; integration sensing (Phase 5) becomes a "weaving team" that synthesizes across subgroups and reports back.
- **Large groups (40+):** The protocol becomes distributed. Phase 2 (contextualize) happens in writing beforehand. Phase 3 (input) uses representative sampling or nested circles. Decisions flow through delegation and modular decision units.

- **Asynchronous/distributed teams:** Phase 4 becomes the default mode rather than the exception. Shared digital spaces replace rooms. The facilitator role shifts toward curation and pattern-harvesting across contributions.

The fractal principle holds: the same pattern language works at every scale, but the *medium* changes.

Adaptation for low-trust and adversarial contexts

The protocol as described assumes a minimum of shared purpose and psychological safety. Many real coordination problems — between organizations, factions, jurisdictions, or stakeholders with conflicting interests — don't have that foundation. The protocol still applies, but several phases need to shift.

From shared decisions to coordinated independent decisions. In adversarial contexts, the actors often don't share a decision space at all. Each party will decide independently. The best achievable outcome is not agreement but *mutual predictability* — a stable configuration of independent actions where no party has incentive to escalate. Phase 6 (decision mode selection) becomes less about choosing a shared mode and more about mapping: "What set of independent actions leads to system stability?" This is coordination without cooperation — and it's often enough.

Catastrophe boundaries replace grounding. The Phase 1 question ("where is your attention?") requires vulnerability that adversarial contexts won't support. Replace it with: "*What outcome must you avoid at all costs?*" This reveals constraints without requiring trust, and it often surfaces a shared catastrophe boundary — a zone that no party wants to enter — which becomes the basis for coordination. Parties that cannot agree on what they want can often agree on what they must prevent.

The elastic zone. After a disruption — a broken agreement, an unexpected escalation, a betrayal of trust — there is usually a narrow band where response is still possible without triggering full collapse. Adaptive facilitation in these moments asks not "how do we respond?" but "*what level of response keeps us inside the zone where recovery remains possible?*" This applies in organizations as much as in geopolitics: the meeting after a leadership betrayal, the negotiation after a partner defects from a deal.

Every action carries a signal layer. In multi-actor systems, decisions have two dimensions: their material impact and their *interpretive* impact — how other actors

will read them. Phase 7 (translate for different audiences) already touches this, but in adversarial contexts it becomes the primary concern throughout the entire process. The question is not just "what do we do?" but "what does what we do *mean* to the other actors in the system?" A response framed as "proportional and complete" produces a fundamentally different system dynamic than the same material action framed as "the first step."

These adaptations don't replace the core protocol — they extend it into terrain where trust is scarce and the coordination problem is between actors who may never share a room, let alone a worldview.

Starting small

A group does not need the full protocol on day one. Even a single element can shift the field:

- Introduce **structured silence** (2–3 minutes of individual reflection before discussion)
- Ask **one systemic question** at the opening ("What are we not seeing?")
- Make **decision mode explicit** ("We're using consent for this, not consensus — here's why")
- Try the **advice process** for one real decision

These are low-cost interventions that produce immediate, tangible results — and they model the possibility of a different way of coordinating without requiring anyone to adopt new terminology.

The organizational immune response. Be aware that introducing even small adaptive elements into a culturally fixed group may trigger resistance. A strategically-oriented group may interpret silence as inefficiency. A procedurally-oriented group may see flexible decision modes as a lack of proper authority. This is normal and predictable.

The most effective approach in resistant contexts is *native-language implementation* — translate the practice into the group's existing value language rather than announcing a new methodology. You don't need to say "we are gathering differentiated input." You can say "to get the best data quickly, let's go around the table once without cross-talk." Speak strategy to strategists. Speak procedure to proceduralists. The underlying adaptive structure does its work whether or not anyone names it.

What to expect in the first three meetings: The first time, structured silence will feel awkward and the systemic question may produce blank looks. The second time, one or two people will use the silence productively and the question will generate a surprising insight. By the third time, the group will begin to protect these elements — they'll notice when they're missing. That's the signal that the ground has shifted.

This protocol draws on Sociocracy, Holacracy, the Advice Process (Laloux), Cynefin (Snowden), Theory U (Scharmer), polarity management (Johnson), developmental psychology (Graves, Beck & Cowan), and integral facilitation principles. For a version of this protocol that uses the developmental stage framework explicitly, see the [Spiralize.org](https://spiralize.org) edition.

See also: [Appendix — Difficult Questions for Adaptive Coordination](#), a curated collection of questions organized by which orientation they challenge.